

Boston, June 20, 1857.

Dear Friend:

172 I am trying to obtain some charitable assistance for a very impoverished family, whose case has recently been brought to my notice; and, knowing your kindness of heart, and your readiness to aid when you have good assurance that your charity will be wisely and mercifully applied, I venture to lay the facts before you.

The case is this. In consequence of a well-written, respectful and touching representation of their unfortunate situation, I was induced to visit an obscure basement room at No. 20, William's Street, in this city, where I found an intelligent, educated and worthy Irishman, Mr. Michael J. Sheehy, with his wife, (an uncommonly good looking woman,) and an interesting little girl about ten years of age, in a state of utter destitution, without even a bed to lie upon. In Ireland, Mr. Sheehy was "a pupil and friend of O'Connell," an active teetotaler with Father Mathew, and an earnest laborer for the redemption of his ill-fated country. He has been in America about four years. The limited means he brought with him gradually became exhausted; till, by a succession of disappointments and misfortunes, he is at last reduced to absolute want, though he has nobly adhered to his anti-slavery and temperance principles. Sorrowful and indignant at the pro-slavery spirit and conduct of his countrymen here, and anxious to win them over to the anti-slavery cause, he wrote a lecture on "O'Connell, the emancipator of British West India slaves—the eloquent advocate of freedom for all of every color, caste and clime," and delivered it (while he had the means) at his own expense in Boston, Taunton, Fall River, New Bedford, &c.; but he was frowned upon by the

Catholic priests, and meeting with no encouragement in any quarter, he could proceed no further. Subsequently, he was burnt out, losing what little he had, together with eighteen dollars in money, enclosed in a book, with which he was about to discharge a debt for clothing. Last spring, he was prostrated with a violent rheumatic fever, (no marvel, in view of his wretched damp abode,) from which he has not yet fully recovered. Besides this, he has a malformation of his right foot. To add to his misfortunes, his wife had to be in the hospital a long time, on account of a dangerous tumor in her jaw. A man of true self-respect, of genuine sensibility of soul, of honorable pride of character, he has kept his sufferings very much to himself till he made his case known to me. As in his own country he moved in very respectable society, and at one period was in more than comfortable circumstances, this reversal of fortune is all the more pitiable; for they who are born in degradation and poverty know nothing of the bitterness of such an experience. I think his case is worthy of special consideration on account of his anti-slavery integrity where so vast a portion of his countrymen are found recreant. I know not when I have seen a suffering family that has impressed me so favorably, or that has so excited my sympathy.

Mr. Sheehy has excellent credentials as to his character, intelligence, and competency, as an accountant, &c. Father Mathew styles him his dear friend, expresses gratification at his recovery from a severe attack of illness, and recommends him as "irritious, well educated, a most zealous tectotaller, and an excellent man." John O'Connell writes him a letter of thanks as one of a committee of condolence on the death of Daniel O'Connell. The Trustees of the Killarney Savings Bank employed Mr. Sheehy as an accountant to wind up the affairs of the Bank; and he has a certificate that, "in the discharge of his duties, he gave great satisfaction; and both Lord Kenmare and Mr. Hoppert,

Mr. P., expressed themselves well pleased with the manner the business was conducted." Thomas Rowcan, Justice of the Peace in this city, certifies that Mr. Sheehy is "in great distress, in consequence of ill health," and that he has "heard him spoken of as one who enjoyed affluence and respect in his native country." Quincy A. Shaw, Esq. (son of the late Robert Ly. Shaw, Esq.) certifies in 1854 "that the letters of character and the credentials of ability, as an accountant which Mr. Sheehy, late of Killybegny, produced to me, were given him by parties who knew him for years. I know them to be authentic and trustworthy."

Mr. Sheehy was at one time connected with the press in Ireland as a reporter, and is an excellent penman, and possesses much skill in composition.

Pecuniary aid and some clothing, as well as a bed, &c., are what his family pressingly need at this moment. Indeed, they are destitute of all the necessaries of life, and deserve to be extricated from their present miserable quarters by a generous co-operative "lift." Next, Mr. S. needs, and is agonizing to find, some kind of employment, whereby he can procure a humble livelihood; for it is painful to such a mind to be seeking eleemosynary aid to keep himself and family from starvation.

I know, my dear friend, that you have many applications for charitable assistance, and that you are constantly taxed in this manner; but I know, also, that you take pleasure in nothing so much as in doing good to the afflicted, and are never weary in this blessed work. Should you feel disposed to contribute anything in this case, in money or clothing, or both, it shall be most gratefully acknowledged and sacredly applied.

Wm. Lloyd Garrison,
Anti-Slavery Office, 21 Cornhill

